IJMSET | Volume 1 | Issue 1 | Oct 2026

International Journal

of Multidisciplinary Science, Engineering & Technology. (IJMSET)

Utilization of Fly Ash for the Production of Artificial Aggregates: Manufacturing Techniques, Engineering Properties and Sustainability in Concrete

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Abstract

The growing demand for construction aggregates has increased pressure on natural resources and highlighted the need for alternative materials with lower environmental impacts. Fly ash, a by-product of coal combustion in thermal power plants, has potential for use in manufacturing artificial aggregates through different processing techniques. This review examines the application of fly ash as a principal constituent in artificial aggregate production, with particular attention to cold bonding, sintering and alkali-activated processes. The effects of raw material characteristics, binder composition, pelletization conditions and curing regimes on aggregate properties are discussed. Published studies indicate that fly ash-based aggregates can achieve lower specific gravity than conventional aggregates, making them potential constituents of lightweight concrete. However, their water absorption, crushing resistance, durability and environmental performance depend on the production method and the chemical and physical characteristics of the starting materials. The review also considers the implications of incorporating these aggregates into concrete, including fresh properties, mechanical strength, thermal performance and long-term durability. Important research needs include standardization of production parameters, assessment of leaching behaviour, long-term performance evaluation and life-cycle analysis. The findings provide a framework for evaluating fly ash as a resource for engineered aggregates and identifying areas for further experimental investigation.

Keywords: Fly ash; artificial aggregates; cold bonding; sintering; lightweight concrete; industrial waste; sustainable construction; aggregate performance.

1. Introduction

Aggregates form a major proportion of concrete and play an important role in determining its physical, mechanical and durability characteristics. The continued expansion of infrastructure has increased the demand for coarse and fine aggregates, creating concerns about the depletion of natural resources and the environmental impacts of extraction. The development of artificial aggregates from industrial by-products is one approach to reducing dependence on conventional aggregate sources while creating opportunities for waste utilization.

Fly ash is a finely divided material collected from the flue gases of coal-fired power plants. Its composition and reactivity depend on the source of coal, combustion conditions and ash collection system. The presence of aluminosilicate phases and, in some cases, calcium-bearing compounds makes fly ash a potential feedstock for manufacturing engineered aggregates. The feasibility of using fly ash for this purpose has been explored through processes such as sintering, cold bonding and autoclaving.

Artificial aggregates produced from fly ash may be used as lightweight coarse aggregates in concrete. Their relatively low density can reduce the self-weight of concrete components, while their production can provide a route for consuming substantial quantities of industrial residue.

However, the final aggregate properties are sensitive to the manufacturing process, binder selection, particle-size distribution and curing conditions.

Sintering involves heating formed pellets at elevated temperatures to develop a hardened structure. It can produce aggregates with favourable mechanical properties, but the required thermal energy and associated emissions need to be considered. Cold bonding, in contrast, uses binders and curing processes to harden the pellets at comparatively low temperatures. It offers a potential alternative where energy consumption and manufacturing emissions are important considerations.

Although the use of fly ash in cement and concrete as a supplementary cementitious material has been widely investigated, the production of aggregate-sized particles presents a different set of engineering challenges. In particular, aggregate crushing resistance, water absorption, particle integrity, compatibility with the cement matrix and environmental safety need to be evaluated before practical application.

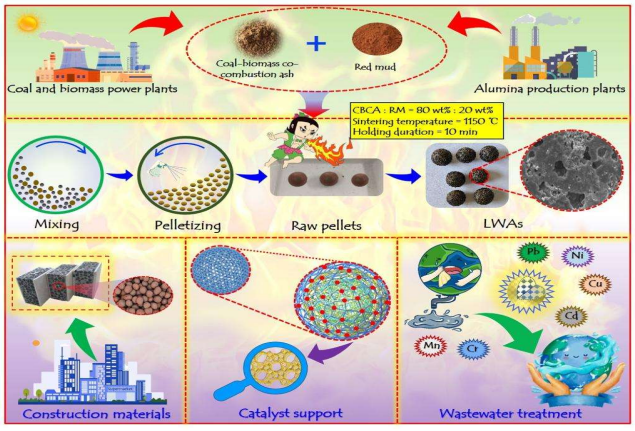
2. Research objectives

The principal objective of this review is to examine the potential of fly ash for producing artificial aggregates and assess their suitability for sustainable concrete.

The specific objectives are:

1. To review the principal manufacturing methods used to produce artificial aggregates from fly ash.
2. To investigate the influence of fly ash characteristics, binder content, pelletization and curing on aggregate performance.
3. To summarize the physical and mechanical properties of fly ash-based aggregates reported in the literature.
4. To examine the effects of artificial fly ash aggregates on the fresh, mechanical and durability properties of concrete.
5. To identify environmental considerations and research gaps relevant to the future development of fly ash-based aggregates.

3. Manufacturing techniques for fly ash-based aggregates



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3.1 Sintering

Sintering generally involves mixing fly ash with appropriate additives, forming pellets and heating them at high temperatures to develop a hardened aggregate structure. The thermal treatment promotes bonding and may produce aggregates with suitable mechanical resistance. The resulting properties depend on the raw material composition, pellet size, heating temperature and residence time.



3.2 Cold bonding

Cold bonding involves mixing fly ash with a binder and water, followed by pelletization and curing. Cement, lime-based binders and other suitable binding systems can be considered. The pellets harden through hydration or other binder-related reactions without requiring high-temperature firing. This process may reduce the energy demand associated with aggregate production, although curing duration and binder-related emissions remain important considerations.

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3.3 Alkali activation

Alkali activation uses alkaline solutions to promote reactions involving reactive aluminosilicate constituents. Fly ash-based pellets can be formed and cured to develop a hardened binder matrix. The aggregate characteristics depend on the precursor composition, activator chemistry, liquid-to-solid ratio and curing conditions. The environmental assessment should also account for the production and handling of alkaline activators.

The three methods involve different energy requirements, reaction mechanisms and processing constraints. Reviews of artificial lightweight aggregates identify the choice of hardening method as a major factor affecting aggregate density, strength and water absorption.

4. Physical and mechanical properties

4.1 Specific gravity and bulk density

The specific gravity of artificial fly ash aggregates is influenced by the porosity and density of the hardened pellets. Published work reports specific gravity values of approximately 1.4–1.9 for some sintered and cold-bonded fly ash aggregates, although these figures are not universal and depend on the particular production method and material composition.
Lower aggregate density can be beneficial for reducing the dead load of concrete structures. However, density should be assessed alongside crushing resistance and absorption because a very porous aggregate may not provide adequate strength or durability for a particular application.

4.2 Water absorption

Water absorption is a key parameter because it influences the effective water content of concrete mixtures, workability and moisture movement within the hardened material. Artificial aggregates produced from fly ash may have higher absorption than conventional crushed stone aggregates due to their pore structure. Appropriate preconditioning and mixture adjustments may therefore be necessary when incorporating these materials into concrete.

4.3 Crushing resistance

Aggregate crushing resistance is essential for evaluating whether pellets can withstand mixing, handling and loading in concrete. Sintered aggregates can develop strong particle bonding through thermal processing, whereas cold-bonded products depend on binder reactions and curing. The suitability of either type should be established by testing rather than inferred from the manufacturing process alone. A published experimental study of cold-bonded fly ash coarse aggregate reported a cylinder compressive strength of 6.2 MPa and water absorption of 6.1% for the specific aggregate investigated.

5. Performance of concrete incorporating fly ash aggregates

The incorporation of artificial fly ash aggregates can influence several properties of concrete. The magnitude and direction of these effects depend on the aggregate characteristics, replacement percentage, moisture condition and concrete mixture design.

Property	Potential effect and research consideration
Workability	Aggregate absorption and surface texture can alter water demand and slump.
Density	Lower-density aggregates may reduce the unit weight of concrete.
Compressive strength	Depends on aggregate strength, paste quality and the bond at the interfacial transition zone.
Tensile and flexural strength	Requires experimental evaluation of cracking behaviour and aggregate–matrix interaction.
Thermal conductivity	Porous lightweight aggregates may help reduce heat transfer.
Durability	Water absorption, permeability, freeze–thaw exposure and chemical resistance require assessment.

A review of sintered fly ash aggregate concrete reported compressive strengths between 27 and 74 MPa and densities between 1,651 and 2,017 kg/m³ across the studies considered. These results demonstrate the range of performance reported for particular sintered aggregate systems, rather than a guaranteed performance range for all fly ash aggregates.

The mechanical performance of concrete also depends on the interface between the aggregate and cement paste. Aggregate surface roughness, porosity and internal strength may influence the interfacial transition zone and the development of cracks under loading. Microstructural

investigations using scanning electron microscopy and energy-dispersive spectroscopy can help explain these interactions.

6. Environmental and sustainability considerations

The conversion of fly ash into artificial aggregates can provide a beneficial use for industrial residues and potentially reduce the extraction of natural aggregates. However, the overall environmental benefit depends on the complete manufacturing and application process.

Sintering may involve significant thermal energy consumption, while cold bonding can reduce the need for high-temperature treatment. Nevertheless, the environmental footprint of cold-bonded aggregates must include the manufacture of cementitious binders, alkaline activators, electricity consumption and transport.

Environmental assessment should also include the possibility of trace-element release from the aggregate. Fly ash composition varies, and the immobilization of potentially hazardous elements cannot be assumed simply because the material has been hardened. Leaching tests under appropriate exposure conditions are necessary to assess environmental suitability. Recent research reviews identify leaching, life-cycle assessment and production-scale feasibility as important areas for future work.

7. Research gaps and future scope

Despite the reported potential of fly ash-based artificial aggregates, several issues require further investigation:

Raw material variability: Differences in coal source and combustion conditions can produce substantial variations in ash composition and reactivity.

Optimization of manufacturing parameters: The effects of pelletization speed, moisture content, binder dosage, pellet size and curing conditions need systematic evaluation.

Long-term durability: More research is needed on sustained loading, wetting and drying, chemical exposure and other relevant service conditions.

Environmental safety: Leaching behaviour should be studied for different aggregate formulations and under representative environmental exposure conditions.

Life-cycle and economic assessment: Comparisons should include energy, binder consumption, transport, production equipment and potential benefits from replacing natural aggregates.

Standardization: Consistent test procedures and performance criteria are needed to facilitate comparison between studies and assess suitability for practical construction.

A further research opportunity is the development of hybrid artificial aggregates containing fly ash and other compatible industrial by-products. Such combinations could allow researchers to

tailor the chemical composition, pore structure and mechanical characteristics of the final aggregate. However, their benefits need to be demonstrated experimentally.

8. Proposed methodology for a systematic review

For a publishable systematic review, the literature search and screening process must be documented and reproducible. The following is a proposed methodology, not a record of a search already conducted.

Database selection

Search Scopus, Web of Science, ScienceDirect and Google Scholar, documenting the date and search coverage of each database.

Search terms

Combine terms such as "fly ash" AND "artificial aggregate", "fly ash" AND "cold bonding", "fly ash aggregate" AND concrete, and "sintered fly ash lightweight aggregate".

Screening

Remove duplicates, screen titles and abstracts, and assess eligible full texts against clearly stated inclusion and exclusion criteria.

Data extraction

Record publication year, fly ash source, chemical composition, manufacturing technique, binder type, curing conditions, aggregate properties and concrete performance.

Critical analysis

Compare results while accounting for differences in materials, test methods, specimen preparation and reporting units.

9. Conclusion

Fly ash has potential as a feedstock for artificial aggregate production through sintering, cold bonding and alkali activation. The resulting aggregates may provide an alternative to conventional natural aggregates and offer opportunities for industrial waste utilization. Published research demonstrates that fly ash-based aggregates can achieve a range of physical and mechanical properties suitable for different concrete applications. However, their practical suitability depends on the interaction between raw material composition, processing parameters, binder selection and curing conditions.

The choice of manufacturing technique involves trade-offs between energy demand, aggregate strength, water absorption, cost and environmental performance. Sintering offers a thermal

route to particle hardening, whereas cold bonding provides an alternative based on binder reactions and curing at comparatively low temperatures. Neither method should be considered environmentally preferable in every situation without a complete assessment of its material and energy inputs.

Future research should focus on reproducible manufacturing protocols, standardized aggregate testing, long-term concrete durability, environmental leaching and life-cycle assessment. These investigations are necessary to establish the technical and environmental conditions under which fly ash-based artificial aggregates can be used reliably in sustainable construction.

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